

The Department of Defense and its Correspondence Relationship with Legislators

PS 699: Independent Study (Spring 2020)

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Introduction

Literature Review

Theory

Design

Data

Altogether we have 7635 letters received by the Department of Defense that are marked as “congressional” from 2007-2017. All of these letters are from Members of the U.S. Congress. Note: During my independent study, I handcoded approximately 3,492 letters from a variety of Department of Defense agencies. Unfortunately, we were not able to implement these observations into the final data set. Thus, observations that are missing a Policy Type Category have a current Type of NA.

A Potential Outlier

In this analysis, Senator Grassley (R-IA) is considered to be an outlier. He wrote 188 letters to the Department of Defense, the most out of any other members of congress. However, he was never a part of any committee that actively work for the Department of Defense. Although at this point, we are unable to see what are the policy categories of the letters he wrote to the Department of Defense, based off of the hand-coding I did, Grassley wrote a majority of his letters on behalf of constituents, specifically for Veterans in Iowa. On further analysis, Grassley’s campaign has largely been based on providing veterans in Iowa opportunities to present their legacy to other residents in Iowa and the US, and more within the realm of congressional agencies, aid with ensuring that veterans receive their benefits after retiring or being discharged from the military. These benefits include disability compensation, education programs, health benefits, and more. A majority of these concerns would be best addressed via the Department of Veteran Affairs versus most of the Department of Defense agencies, however, many of the issues, such as Military Pay complaints as well as sexual harrassment allegations can indeed be addressed with the Department of Defense agencies, such as the Department of Defense and Accounting Service (DFAS) as well as the Office of the Inspector General, U.S. Department of Defense (DOD_OIG). Thus, at this time, I am not considering Senator Grassley to be an outlier in my analysis.

Table 1: Top Policy Categories within Grassley’s Letters to the DOD

bioname	party	TYPE	cqlabel	n
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	NA	(IA)	168
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	1	(IA)	19
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	5	(IA)	1

Top 10 Legislators who wrote the most letters to the DOD

Except for Senator Grassley, many of the legislators who most frequently wrote letters to the DOD were

Table 2: Legislators who wrote the most letters to DOD

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	Senate	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY TA
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	House	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
McCAIN, John Sidney, III	(R)	Senate	(AZ)	ARMED SERVICES HOMELAND SECURITY INDIAN
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	Senate	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE AGING
HUNTER, Duncan Duane	(R)	House	(CA-50)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION TRANSPORTATION
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
McCASKILL, Claire	(D)	Senate	(MO)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE HOMELAND SECUR
OBEY, David Ross	(D)	House	(WI-07)	APPROPRIATIONS
WOLF, Frank Rudolph	(R)	House	(VA-10)	APPROPRIATIONS
WITTMAN, Robert J.	(R)	House	(VA-01)	ARMED SERVICES NATURAL RESOURCES

Table 3: Policy Categories within Legislators’ Letters to the DOD

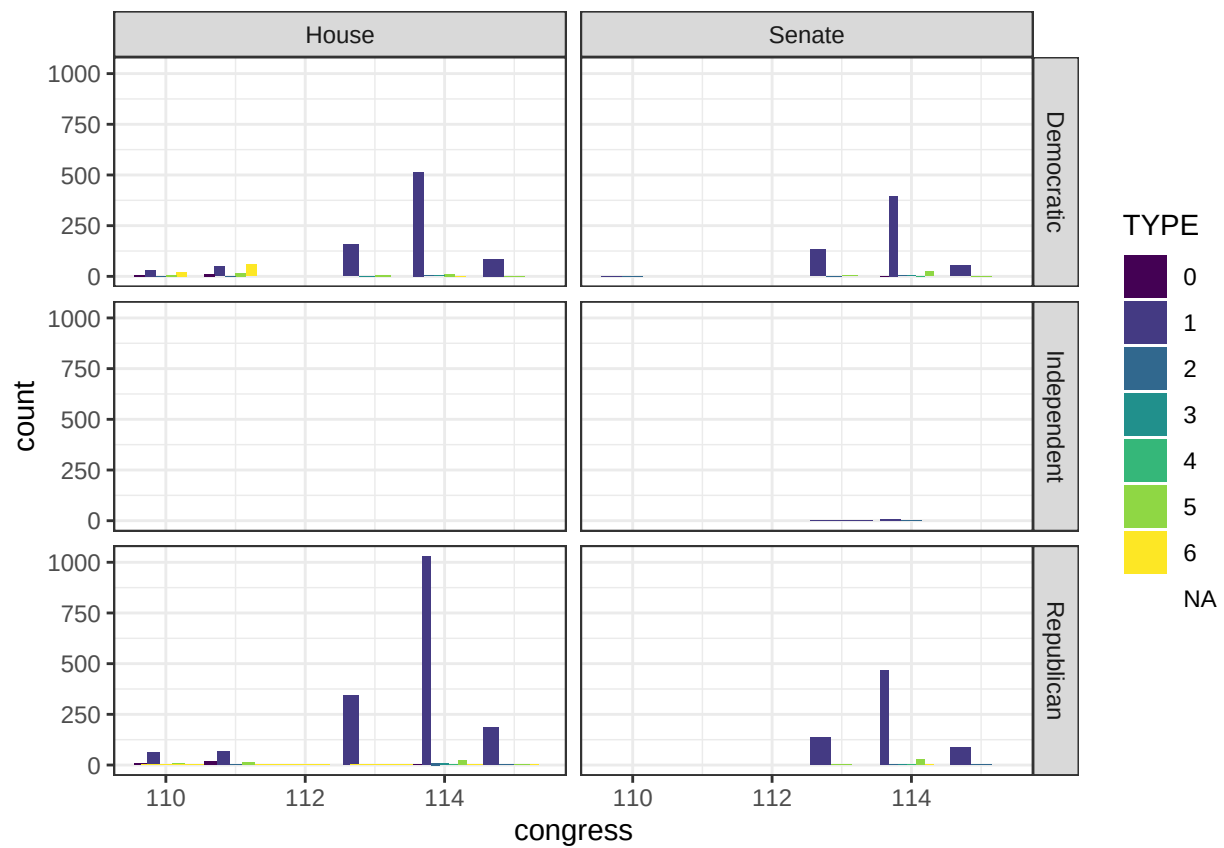
bioname	party	chamber	TYPE	cqlabel	committees
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	Senate	NA	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	House	NA	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
WEBB, James H. (Jim)	(D)	Senate	NA	(VA)	ARMED SERVICES FOREIGN RELATIONS
McCASKILL, Claire	(D)	Senate	NA	(MO)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE HOMELAND
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	Senate	1	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	6	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
BOOZMAN, John	(R)	Senate	1	(AR)	AGRICULTURE APPROPRIATIONS ENVIR
OBEY, David Ross	(D)	House	6	(WI-07)	APPROPRIATIONS
TOOMEY, Patrick Joseph	(R)	Senate	1	(PA)	BANKING BUDGET FINANCE
GRAHAM, Lindsey O.	(R)	Senate	1	(SC)	APPROPRIATIONS ARMED SERVICES BUD
WOLF, Frank Rudolph	(R)	House	1	(VA-10)	APPROPRIATIONS

Table 4: Most Common Policy Areas

TYPE	n
1	3798
5	149
6	88
0	43

TYPE	n
2	35
3	25
4	3

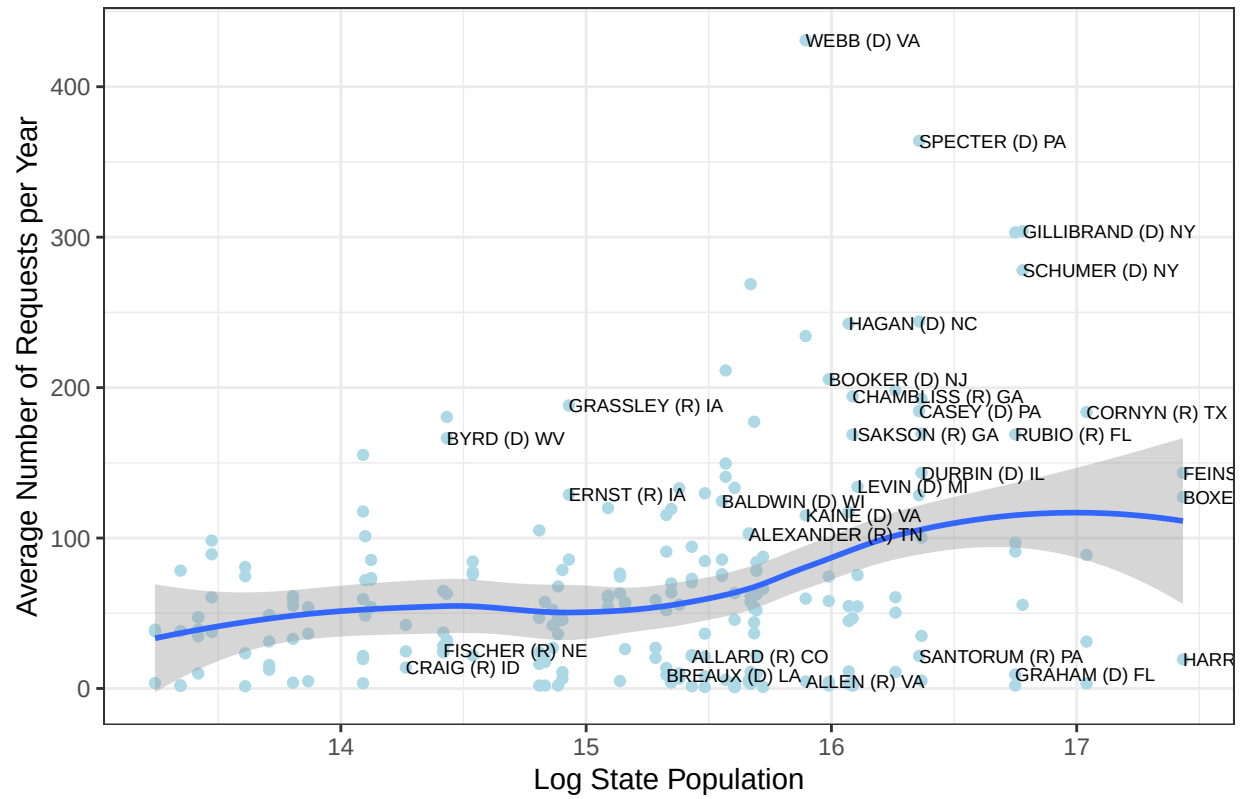
Warning: position_dodge requires non-overlapping x intervals



Senators Versus State Population for all Agencies

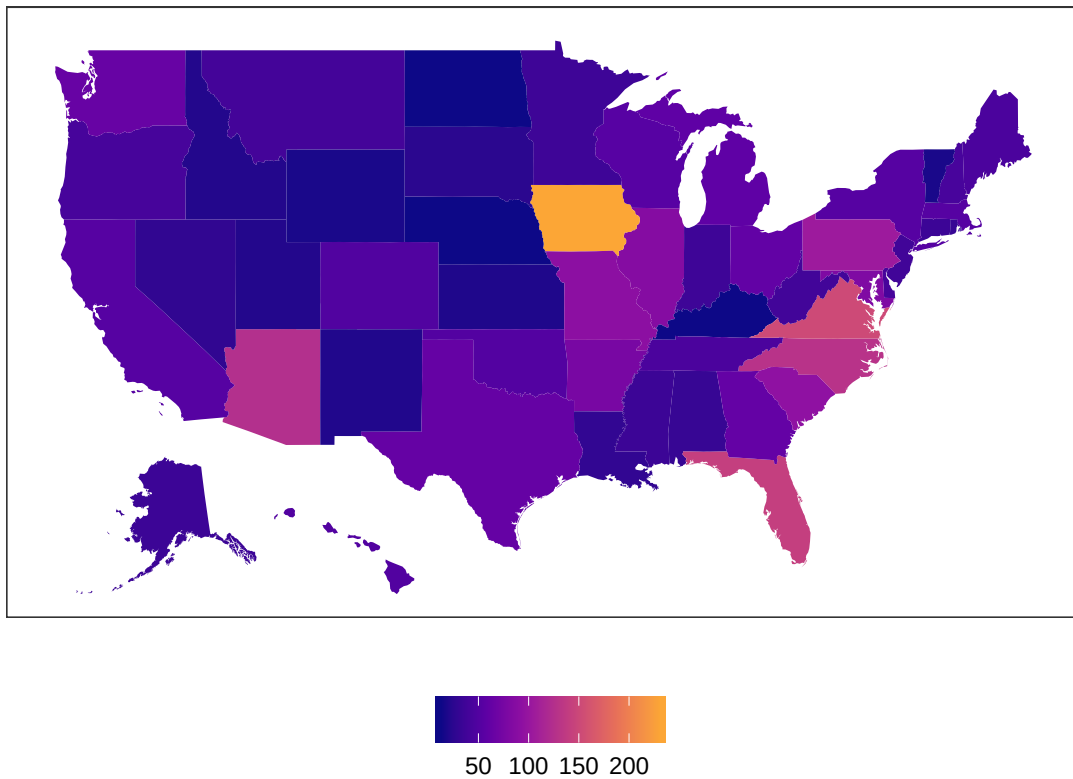
`geom\_smooth()` using method = 'loess' and formula 'y ~ x'

Senator Requests per Year by State Population



Senators Versus State Population for DOD

Total Number of Contacts from members of the Senate

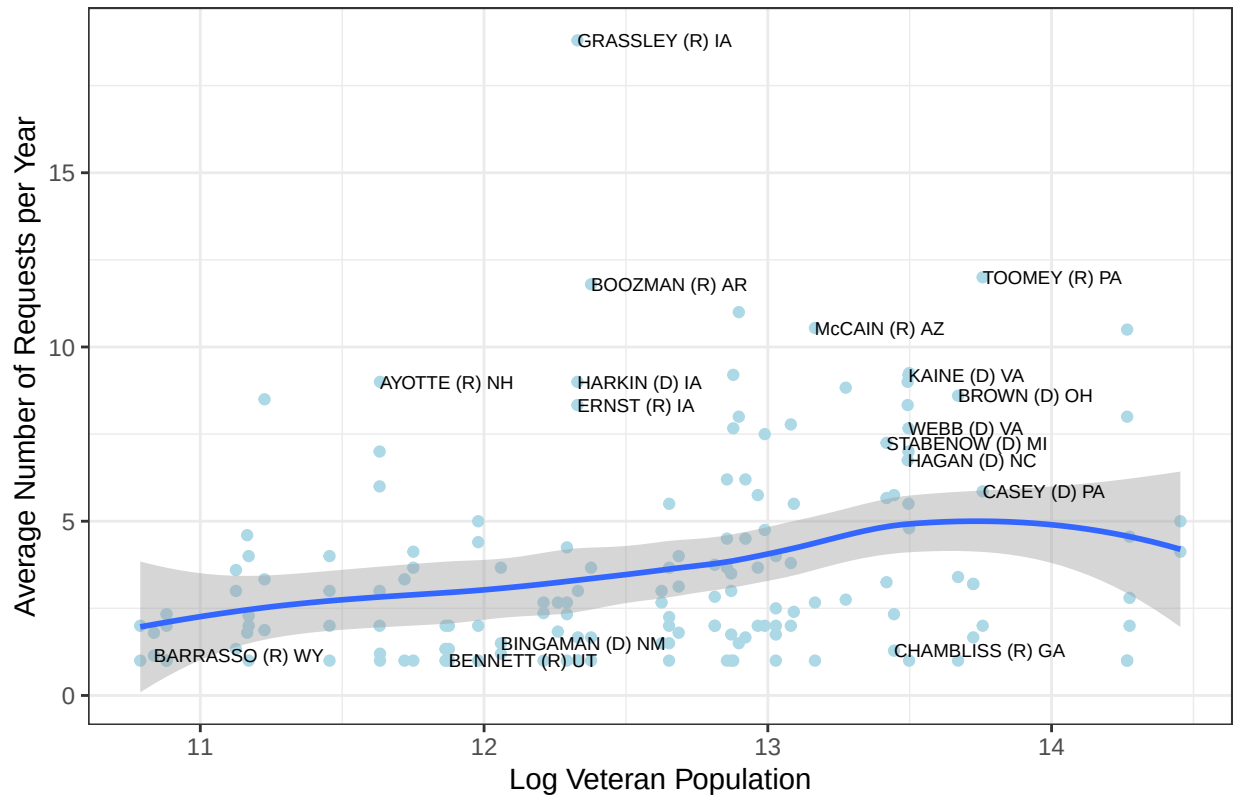


A choropleth map of the United States showing the percentage of the population aged 18-24 in 2010. The map uses a color scale from dark purple (low percentage) to bright orange (high percentage). States with the highest percentages (orange/red) include Alaska, Hawaii, and several states in the Northeast and West. States with the lowest percentages (dark purple) include Texas, Florida, and several states in the South and Midwest.

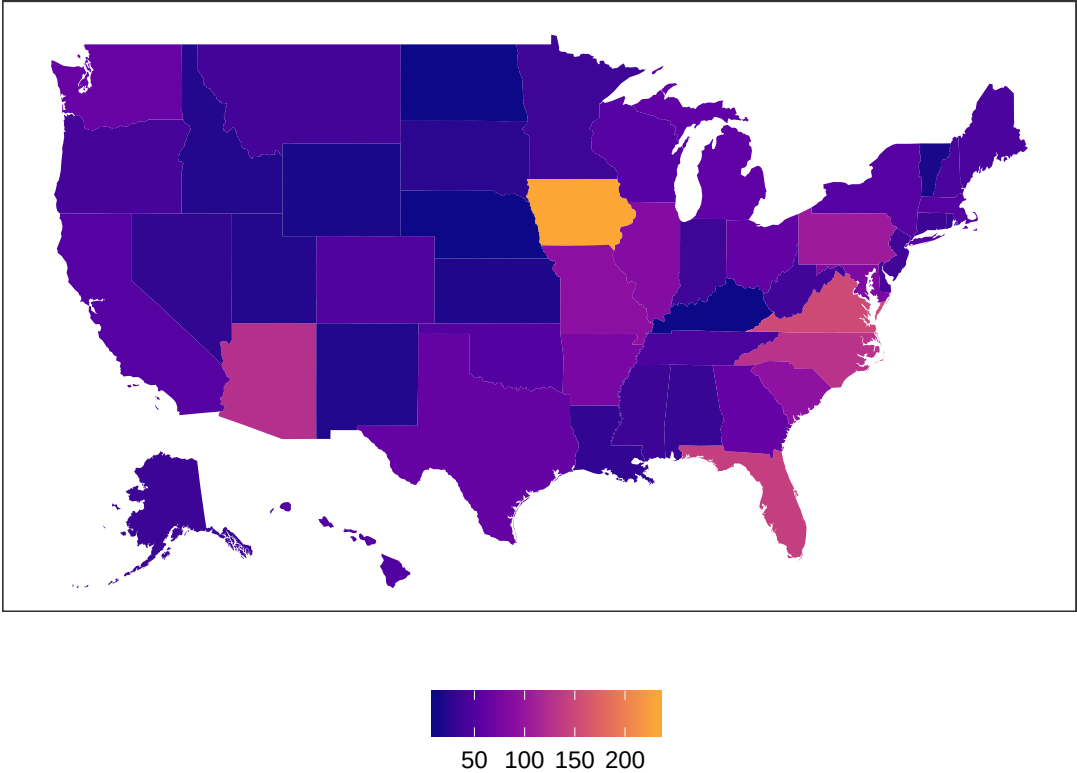
```
## Joining, by = "state"

## `geom_smooth()` using method = 'loess' and formula 'y ~ x'
```

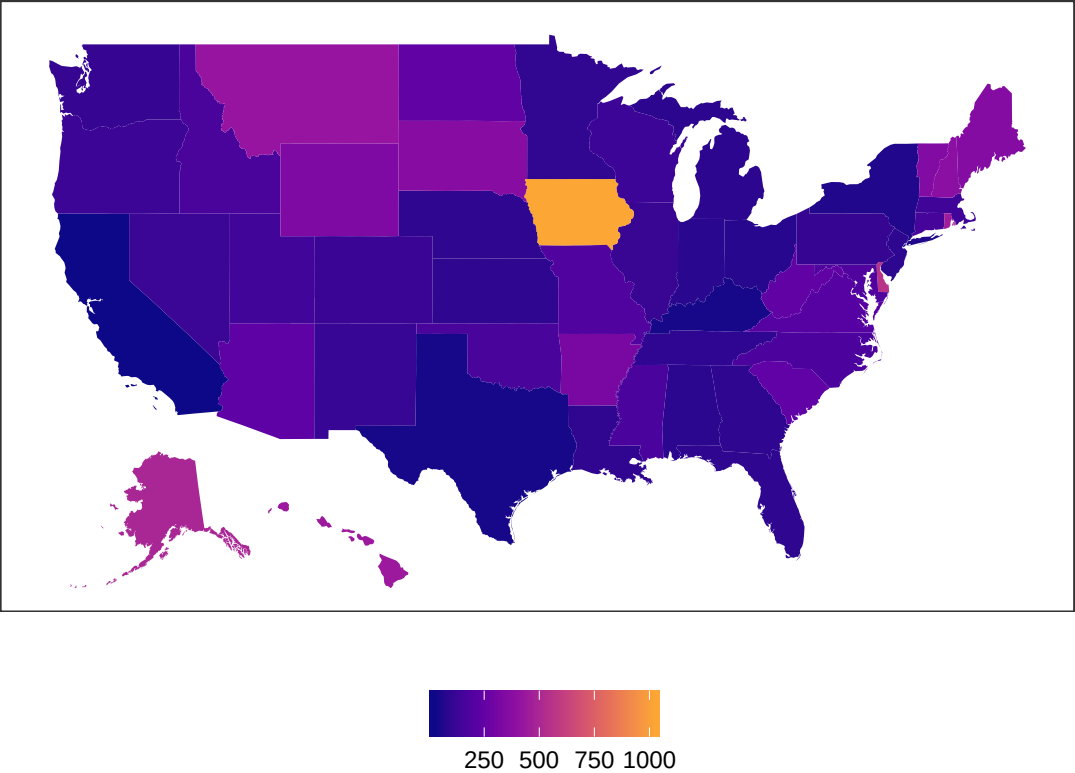
Senator Requests per Year by Veteran Population



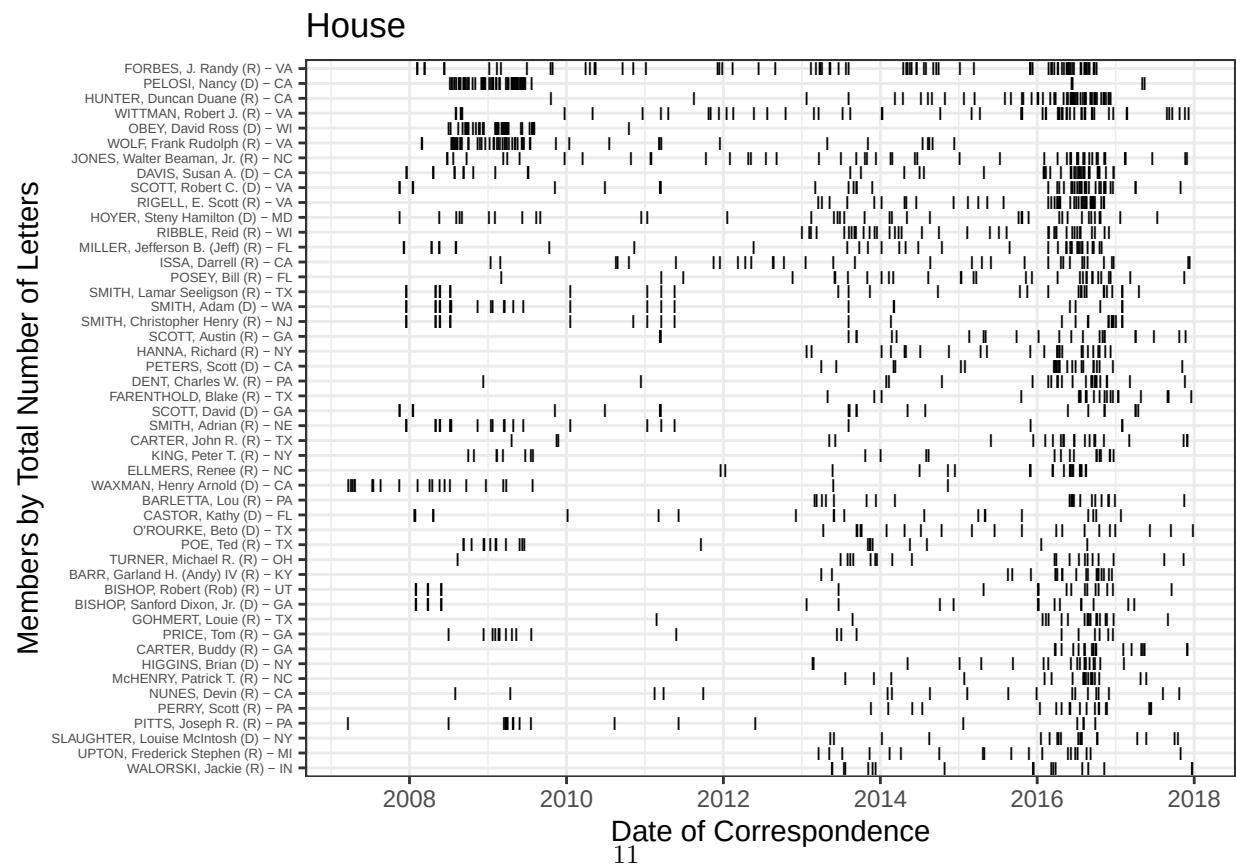
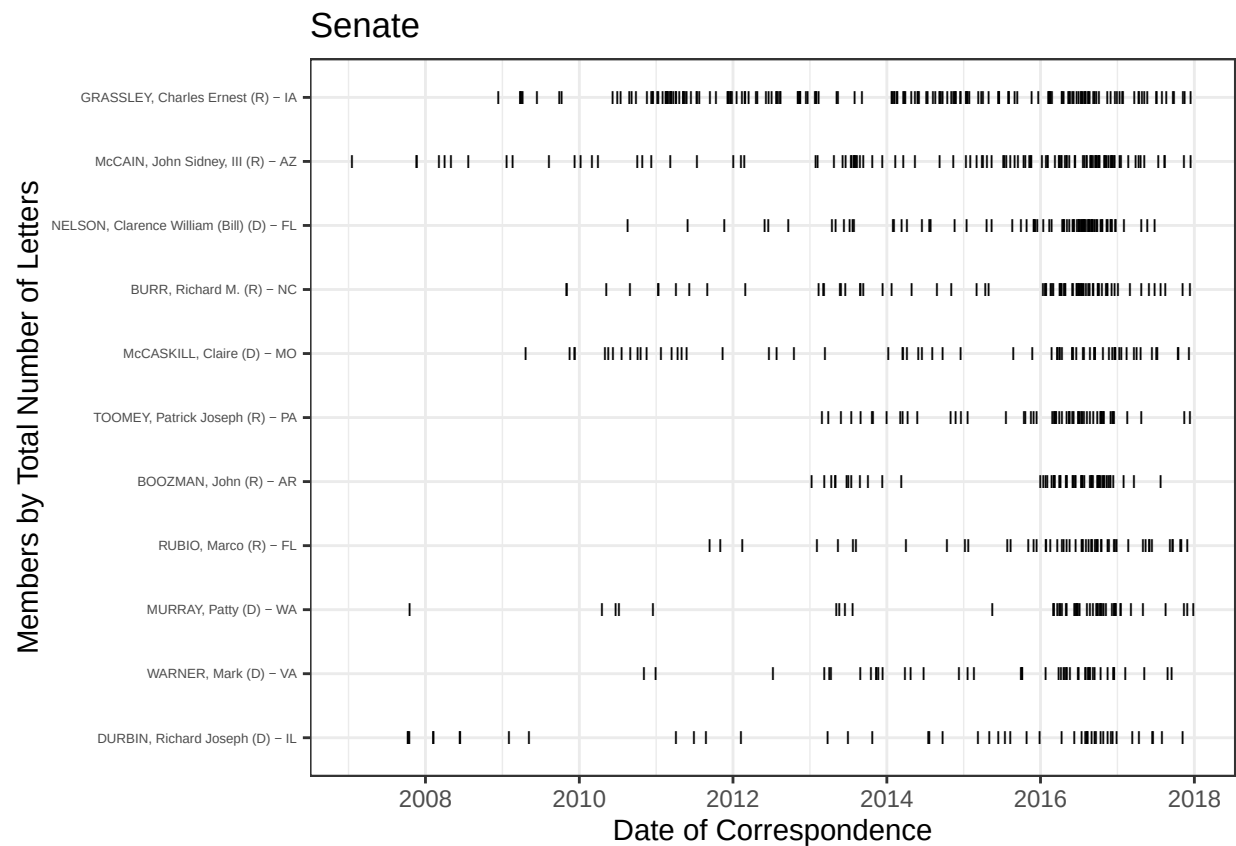
Total Number of Contacts from members of the Senate per Veteran Popula



Contacts Per Million Veteran Residents from Members of the Senate

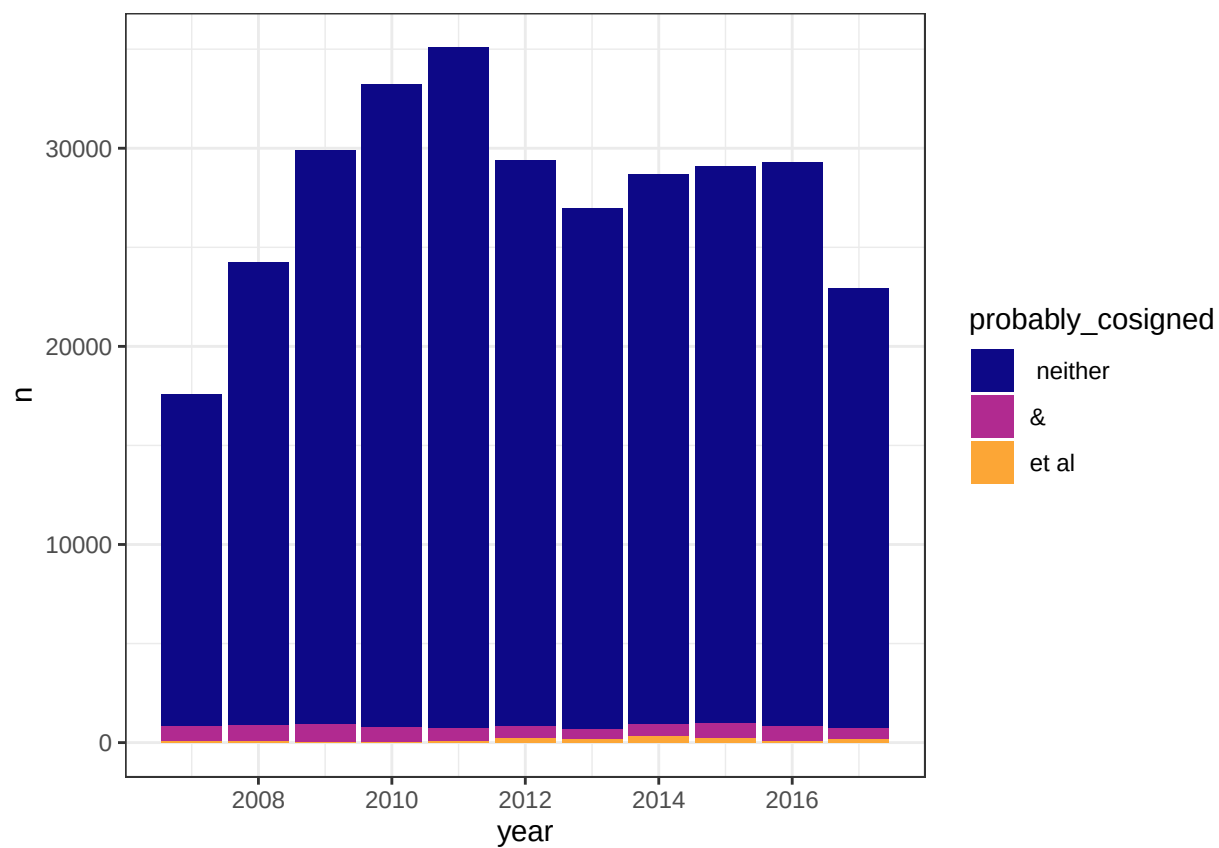


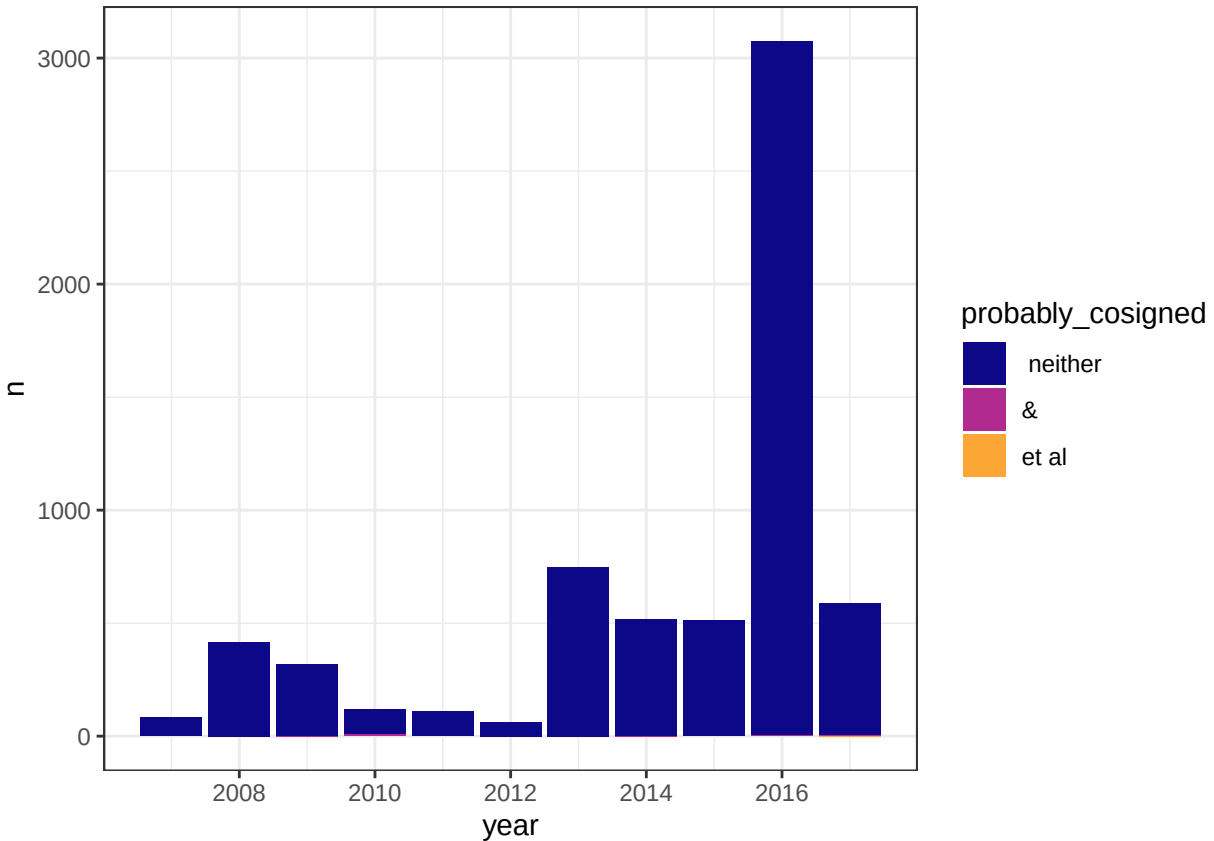
Members who contact DOD more than average:



Are letters to the DOD Cosigned?

A rough under-estimate based on whether “et al” or “&” appears in the summary:





##How to fix this committee Code

#Left join committees into all_contacts #Group by ICPSR and Congress #Summarize committees = paste committee #Full join of all contacts and committees, larger data set

Modify committees variable, ICPSR, Congress, Committee= Armed Services

7635 and 99

Top Female Legislators who wrote the most letters to the DOD

Table 5: Female Legislators who wrote the most letters to DOD

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
BROWNLEY, Julia	(D)	House	(CA-26)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
ELLMERS, Renee	(R)	House	(NC-02)	ENERGY
GILLIBRAND, Kirsten	(D)	Senate	(NY)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES ENVIRONMENT
EDWARDS, Donna F.	(D)	House	(MD-04)	TRANSPORTATION SCIENCE

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY
SLAUGHTER, Louise McIntosh	(D)	House	(NY-25)	RULES
TITUS, Alice (Dina)	(D)	House	(NV-01)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS

Table 6: Female Relevant Committee Members who wrote the most letters to DOD according

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
BROWNLEY, Julia	(D)	House	(CA-26)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
GILLIBRAND, Kirsten	(D)	Senate	(NY)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES ENVIRONMENT A
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY
TITUS, Alice (Dina)	(D)	House	(NV-01)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
PINGREE, Chellie	(D)	House	(ME-01)	APPROPRIATIONS
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS COMMERCE HEALTH
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION HOUSE ADMINISTRA
HERRERA BEUTLER, Jaime	(R)	House	(WA-03)	APPROPRIATIONS
MILLER, Candice S.	(R)	House	(MI-10)	ARMED SERVICES TRANSPORTATION HOMELAND S

Multivariate Models

Conclusion

Limitations throughout the Independent Study

Throughout the course of this independent study, there were a few limitations I faced

Future ideas to explore with this paper

In the future, I hope to continue my exploration with this topic by analyzing some different aspects to help evaluate the overlying question of how Department of Defense agencies interact with constituents and legislators.

Representative Gender Policy Stuff Bipartisan relationships Businesses Electoral Interests Members who contact DOD more, relative to other agencies: Veteran Status —

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Notes:

1. Count letters by member by year (including zero counts)
2. Policy Stuff
3. Divide by years--annualized by years
4. Control with Gender--how long they're in congress
5. Veterans--More likely to write, shared Veteran status. Veterans-gender-bias
6. What Kind of Variate Models??--Pro-business/anti-business/Constituent vs. everyone else/ Party Explanatory #Party # constituent vs non constituent gender
7. Include Appendix??